

Q: What things have you learned about Stone Age people?

A: I mostly study the Neanderthals, and they never cease to surprise me. Archaeologists used to write about them as if they were hardly human. We now know that they were people just like us—they just had different ways of living.

Q: What is your most amazing find?

A: The find I'm proudest of is a henge! It was hard to see at first because the ditch was infilled with gravel. I was really pleased—not just that we'd found it, but that I'd stuck to my guns when no one believed me!

Q: Could you describe a typical day in your work?

A: If I'm in the field, then we get up early and spend the day on site digging. We remove sediment carefully with trowels, leaving all the stone tools exactly where we found them. Then we plot exactly where the tools are, and lift them one at a time. They go straight into bags with all the details of where they came from written on them. When we get back to our camp in the evening we make sure these details are put onto computers.

Q: What sort of equipment do you use?

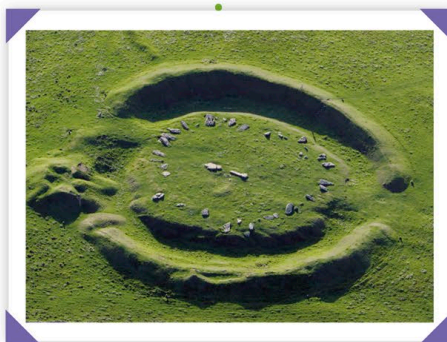
A: It depends what I'm doing. We use shovels and mattocks, or pickaxes, then trowels, and finally, if you're cleaning around delicate bones or flints, we might use plastic tools. We hardly ever use brushes, despite what you see in films!

Q: What is the most difficult part of your job?

A: I'm not a very patient person, and sometimes you have to be patient as an archaeologist. It takes time to excavate carefully. You need to finish what you're doing, understand it, and then move on.

Q: Do you have any advice for future archaeologists?

A: Look at everything like an archaeologist! When you go to the beach, see how people choose to sit around, and the marks that they leave behind. How do the marks relate to what you saw? Imagine finding the contents of your pockets in the future: what would rot away, and what would people think about you based on what survived? You don't have to dig holes to be an archaeologist—it's a way of looking at people through things.



A henge is a Neolithic monument with a circular ditch and bank. This henge is in Derbyshire, England.

